



Swift Is Repositioning

Coordination and orchestration layer
for tokenised and multi-rail finance

SWIFT Is Repositioning in the Financial Stack

From:

Global financial messaging network connecting 11,500+ institutions across 200+ countries and supporting more than 40,000 payment routes

To:

Coordination and orchestration layer for tokenised and multi-rail finance

SWIFT is now extending the role beyond messaging into coordination and orchestration for tokenised and multi-rail finance.

The shift is about synchronising transaction state across institutions that now operate across bank ledgers, tokenised asset platforms, and multiple settlement rails.

From transmitting messages

→ to synchronizing transaction state across systems

SWIFT is Building a Shared Ledger for Tokenised Asset Workflows

- Completed design phase (2024–2025)
- Now developing a live MVP (production-oriented testing)

Focus

- Tokenised deposits (bank liabilities on-chain)
- Cross-border coordination between institutions

Target

Live transaction pilots starting 2026

The first use case is 24/7 cross-border payments, with the ledger intended to support interoperability between tokenised deposits and existing payment infrastructure.

Swift says the platform is being built to help the industry adopt new forms of regulated digital value safely and consistently, rather than to create a parallel network.

This moves SWIFT from:

standards & messaging

→ to active infrastructure layer in transaction flows

Solving Fragmentation Across Financial Systems

Today's reality

- Banks operate separate internal ledgers
- Tokenised assets exist on isolated blockchains
- Payments run on multiple rails (RTGS, card, correspondent banking)

Key issue

No shared transaction state across systems

Result

- Reconciliation costs
- Delayed settlement
- Operational risk

SWIFT's objective

Enable interoperability across systems without forcing standardization at the infrastructure level

The Shared Ledger

Shared ledger = coordination layer

The system introduces:

- Pre-settlement transaction recording (commitments between counterparties)
- Synchronized state updates across institutions
- Transaction validation before settlement execution

Support for:

- DvP (Delivery vs Payment)
- PvP (Payment vs Payment)

The shared ledger is designed to record and validate interbank transaction commitments before settlement, synchronise transaction state across counterparties, and enable more precise coordination of payment-versus-payment and delivery-versus-payment workflows. This matters because the challenge in multi-rail finance is not only moving value. It is ensuring that institutions, assets, and settlement conditions remain aligned throughout the lifecycle of a transaction. SWIFT's model moves the system from bilateral message exchange toward shared transaction synchronisation.

Key shift

From bilateral messaging to shared, synchronized transaction state across participants

Where SWIFT Sits in the Transaction Lifecycle

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Position in the Financial Stack

SWIFT = Coordination & Messaging Layer

In the architecture:

- **Issuance:** Stablecoins, tokenised deposits
- **Execution:** RTGS, instant payment systems
- **Liquidity:** Market makers, bank balance sheets
- **Custody** Banks, custodians, MPC providers
- **Coordination** SWIFT

In a layered architecture, issuers create digital money, settlement systems move it, liquidity providers make execution possible, and custodians secure assets and entitlements.

SWIFT sits above these layers as the coordination and messaging layer.

Its role is to connect money creation, transaction execution, and asset control into a synchronised system. That is why SWIFT's ledger matters. It does not compete directly with issuers, custodians, or settlement systems. It seeks to make them interoperable.

SWIFT links:

- money creation
- value movement
- asset control

into a synchronized system

Role in Transaction Lifecycle

Where SWIFT sits

Traditional flow: Messaging → clearing → settlement

Issues:

- Asynchronous systems
- Multiple reconciliation steps
- Settlement risk (timing mismatch)

Emerging flow: Messaging + coordination → synchronized execution → settlement

SWIFT now

- Aligns transaction state before settlement occurs
- Ensures both sides agree on transaction conditions
- Reduces:
 - reconciliation
 - failed transactions
 - settlement delays

SWIFT becomes the pre-settlement control layer

Technical Architecture

Enterprise DLT, EVM-compatible

- Built on EVM-compatible infrastructure (Hyperledger Besu)
- Enables:
 - Smart contract-based coordination logic
 - Compatibility with tokenised asset platforms
- Integrated with:
 - ISO 20022 messaging standard (global migration ongoing)
 - Existing compliance and identity frameworks

The architecture is intended to support smart contract-based coordination logic while remaining compatible with existing banking standards, APIs, messaging formats, and compliance requirements. The design principle is not public-blockchain substitution. It is interoperability between traditional banking systems and digital asset environments using enterprise-grade infrastructure.

Design principle:

Interoperate with both:

- traditional banking systems
- emerging on-chain financial infrastructure

Institutional Participation and System Scale

System-level collaboration

Developed with:

- 30+ global banks across ~16 countries
- Expanded design group: 40+ institutions

SWIFT network scale:

- 11,500+ institutions
- 200+ countries and territories
- Handles ~\$150T+ equivalent annual messaging flows (industry estimates)

That work is taking place on top of a network that already connects more than 11,500 institutions across over 220 countries and territories. The scale matters because SWIFT's value is not just technical interoperability. It is the combination of reach, trust, resilience, and common standards.

Impact

This is a core global financial infrastructure

What SWIFT is NOT Doing

No new rail. No settlement layer. No disintermediation.

SWIFT is not:

- A new payment network
- A replacement for RTGS / central bank systems
- A settlement asset issuer
- A blockchain-based value transfer system

And it is not positioning itself as an on-chain value-transfer network in the crypto-native sense. Its role remains above the settlement layer.

The ledger is intended to coordinate transactions across existing and emerging forms of regulated value, embedding controls, compliance, and orchestration into the flow rather than moving value directly itself.

Instead

It operates **above existing infrastructure**

As:

Coordination + orchestration layer

Aligned with Europe's System-Level Design

Europe is uniquely structured:

- MiCA (2024–2025)
 - → regulated stablecoins and digital assets
- Instant Payments Regulation
 - → mandatory real-time payments across EU
- ISO 20022 migration
 - → standardized data layer across banks

Europe is one of the most relevant environments for this development because regulation and infrastructure are moving in parallel. MiCA creates a formal framework for regulated digital assets and stablecoins. The Instant Payments Regulation pushes the market toward mandatory real-time euro payments. ISO 20022 migration standardises data structures across banks and payment infrastructures. In that environment,

SWIFT's move is strategically coherent: it extends Europe's system-level approach from domestic and regional infrastructure into cross-border coordination for tokenised and multi-rail finance.

SWIFT extends this:

From domestic / regional systems to cross-border coordination across all layers

Strategic Implication

Messaging → synchronization → control

SWIFT is evolving into:

- Multi-rail coordination layer
- Transaction synchronization layer
- Cross-system orchestration layer

→ infrastructure for transaction synchronization
across the financial system

The most important implication is not technological. It is architectural. Historically, control sat with the rail that moved the payment. In a multi-rail system, control increasingly sits with the layer that can coordinate across rails, assets, and institutions.

SWIFT is evolving into exactly that layer: a platform for multi-rail coordination, transaction synchronisation, and cross-system orchestration. This is why the shared-ledger initiative matters far beyond digital assets alone. It is about who manages interoperability in the next phase of financial infrastructure.

This changes where control sits:

From rails (payments, settlement systems)
to systems that coordinate across them

Financial Infrastructure is Becoming Multi-Layer and Multi-Rail

The financial system is becoming simultaneously more digital, more tokenised, and more multi-rail. Issuers define money. Settlement systems move value. Custodians secure assets and permissions. Liquidity providers support execution.

In this system:

- **Issuers** define money
- **Settlement** systems move value
- **Custodians** secure assets

SWIFT ensures all **systems operate in sync**

In that system, coordination becomes a separate and increasingly critical function. SWIFT's repositioning is best understood in that light. It is not trying to become every layer. It is trying to become the layer that keeps the others in sync.

It reflects a broader transition in finance: from isolated systems connected by messages to interoperable systems connected by synchronised transaction state.

For institutions working on tokenised deposits, digital cash, or cross-border settlement, that is the development to follow.



Infrastructure for transaction synchronization
across the financial systems.

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